

	Division/Section	Family Support
	Chapter No./Name	4 – Economic Stability (ES)
	Part No./Name	P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program
	Section No./Name	P-700-STEP Supportive Services
	Document No./Name	P-760-STEP Payment Option-Direct Deposit and Stored Value Cards
	Effective Date	January 1, 2021

I. STATEMENT OF POLICY

STEP supportive service payments are disbursed electronically. The electronic disbursements include Direct Deposits to the client's bank account (checking or savings) or payments to a Stored Value Card account.

P-761-STEP - PO DIRECT DEPOSIT

Direct deposit is the electronic transfer of funds to the participant's checking or savings account.

P-762-STEP - PO STORED VALUE CARD (SVC)

A Stored Value Card is the commercial term for a card-accessed account system where payments are electronically deposited in an account accessible for cash withdrawal or for credit purchases, similar to a debit card.

P-763-STEP - PO * STAFF ** RESPONSIBILITIES

Staff shall follow departmental procedures when informing FITAP applicants and STEP participants of payment methods and when managing payment errors contained in various * LITE Pentaho reports. **

II. PROCEDURES

STEP participants will select the payment method preferred. * The STEP Coach will enter the client's checking or savings account information in LITE, or will enroll the client in a SVC account if they do not already have an existing SVC account. ** ***

P-761-STEP - PR DIRECT DEPOSIT

STEP participants who choose Direct Deposit must:

- Have an active checking or savings account in their name.
- Submit a completed Direct Deposit Authorization Form ([OFS DD 1](#)) with the required documentation for the selected method of deposit;
 - For checking accounts, a voided check
 - For savings accounts, a statement from the financial institution showing the participant's account number and routing number.

Note: If a voided check is unavailable, a statement from the financial institution is required.

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If the participant's name on the Direct Deposit Authorization Form ([OFS DD 1](#)) differs in any way from their name on their STEP case, the [OFS DD 1](#) must be returned for proper completion.

To change or cancel the Direct Deposit account, the STEP participant must notify DCFS in writing by completing the [OFS DD 1](#). When the STEP participant changes or cancels Direct Deposit, he should be given the option of providing new account information or being issued a Stored Value Card (SVC).

Information regarding payments made by Direct Deposit into the participant's checking or savings account can be obtained from the participant's financial institution.

P-761-STEP - PR STORED VALUE CARD (SVC)

An SVC will be issued to the * STEP participant who chooses SVC as their preferred payment method. ** ***

The SVC can be used to make purchases, get cash, and pay bills anywhere MasterCard debit is accepted. If cash is required, funds can be withdrawn from the card at an U.S. Bank, MoneyPass, and Allpoint ATM machine for free. If an Out of Network ATM is accessed, the client will be charged a small fee. Participants must activate their pre-paid SVC debit card by following the contracted financial institution (U.S. Bank) activation instructions.

One SVC will be used for all funds payable by DCFS to the cardholder. STEP participants receiving payments through a SVC who also receive child support payments from Child Support Enforcement will be issued only one card for all payments. * An automated *Stored Value Card STEP Notice* will be generated and mailed once in a lifetime for a STEP participant to notify them that they were previously issued a SVC and their STEP payments will be sent to the existing SVC account. LITE generates this notice when a user clicks "Check for existing SVC" button and the interface populates the existing SVC account information in LITE.

If a client's address changes, the ES eligibility worker must update the client's mailing address on their FITAP case. The updated address will be sent to the SVC account in the nightly batch. Advise clients that their address change will generally need two business days to be updated on their SVC account. After the address is updated on the SVC account, the client must then call U.S. Bank to request a replacement card if one is needed.

The client must activate the SVC card before their pending STEP Supportive Service payments will issue. Once activated, the nightly batch interfaces will generally need two business days before the funds will be available in the SVC account. ** ***

P-763-STEP - PR * STAFF ** RESPONSIBILITIES

The * FITAP intake worker is responsible for informing the FITAP applicant and the STEP Coach ** is responsible for informing the STEP participant of the payment methods.

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* The Direct Deposit/SVC Information Sheet ([OFS DD 1 IS](#)) is automatically mailed to the applicant/recipient as a tool in selecting a payment option at certification. If Direct Deposit is chosen, the STEP Coach ** should provide an [OFS DD 1](#) to the recipient to obtain their checking or savings account information.

Once the payment method has been established, the * STEP Coach must update the banking or SVC information on the LITE Stored Value Card/Direct Deposit screen ** immediately so the STEP participants' supportive service payments will be issued timely.

The * STEP Coach is responsible for reviewing LITE Pentaho ** reports daily and making on-line corrections as necessary.

The * LITE Pentaho reports that must be reviewed daily are:

1. STEP Clients with Common Database Mismatches,
2. STEP EFT Pre Note Error Return Report, *** and the ** ***
3. * STEP SVC Enrollment Error Return Report. ***

The following * LITE Pentaho report must be reviewed monthly and appropriate action taken:

STEP Payments Pending Over 30 Days/EFT Error

This report is generated on the last day of the month for all STEP clients who have:

- an issuance status of "Pending" for over 30 days from the Process Date for a STEP Supportive Service Payment. The Process Date is the date that the payment created in the STEP Referrals module is moved by LITE to the Benefit Maintenance Module; or
- an Electronic Funds Transfer (EFT) error that has been "Pending" for more than 30 days. EFT errors are issuances that were issued as "Paid", but were rejected by the financial institution due to an error in the banking information and returned to DCFS. Once returned, the "Paid" issuance status was reset to "Pending" because the payment was rejected.

Pending payments must be researched to determine the cause of the error. The error must be corrected if possible.

If the documentation indicates additional participant contact or system updates are required to correct the problem, take appropriate action and monitor the case until the banking information is activated and the (funds) payables are deposited. The nightly batch process will automatically re-check the banking information to determine if the Pending payment can be released into an account. **

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If it is determined that the STEP participant is eligible for the aging * “Pending” status payment after research, but direct deposit cannot be made by EFT to an SVC, checking, or savings account, the aging “Pending” status payment can be issued by a manual ** paper check ***. * A manual paper check may be issued if the documentation indicates the following:

- Recent contact has been made with the STEP participant, and
- The participant is eligible to receive payment, but
- Direct deposit cannot be made to an SVC, checking, or savings account, and
- The participant agrees that they are able to cash a paper check.

The STEP Coach ** *** must request guidance and approval from the * STEP Supervisor, who will approve the request and contact the Economic Stability Regional Consultant for technical assistance **. *** A * manual paper check can only be issued if the issuance status is “Pending ** ***”.

* Cancel the “Pending” payment and send Notice of Action Regarding Transportation and Other Supportive Services (STEP 12) to the last known address notifying the client that benefits will be terminated if:

- the documentation indicates all efforts to assist the participant to secure an active SVC account or valid direct deposit information have been exhausted,
- it is determined that the STEP participant is ineligible for the aging “Pending” status payment,
- the mail is returned, or
- the participant’s whereabouts are unknown. **

III. FORMS AND INSTRUCTIONS

DD 1 [Form/Instructions](#) Direct Deposit Authorization-STEP

DD1 IS [Form/Instructions](#) Direct Deposit-SVC Informational Sheet

STEP 12 [Form/Instructions](#) Notice of Action-Transportation and Other Supportive Services

IV. REFERENCES

[LAC 67:III.5729](#)